

CONTENDER-IN-CHIEF
Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav at a press conference in Lucknow on January 22

Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**

That's a fact. He has won five consecutive elections to the Gorakhpur Lok Sabha seat. This time, it's a battle of somewhat different contours, though. And the stakes are incredibly high for both the 49-year-old Adityanath and the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). The election to the UP assembly is like the very axis on which Indian democracy spins. And Adityanath will create history of sorts if he is re-elected—no UP chief minister before him has ever won a second consecutive term after completing a full first tenure. (N.D. Tiwari did win two consecutive terms in 1985, but his first term lasted only seven months, and his second, six.) If he pulls off that feat, it will put the stamp of popular approval on Adityanath's leadership and position him ahead of most others in the BJP as the party's prime ministerial aspirant to succeed Narendra Modi.

For the BJP, a big win in UP will give it a major impetus to win a third consecutive parliamentary election in 2024. In the short term, it will enable the party to dictate who will become the next President when polls are held in July. (UP, with its 403 assembly seats, 100 legislative council members, 80 Lok Sabha members and 31 Rajya Sabha members, contributes the maximum votes to the electoral college). In the longer term, a decisive mandate in UP will also be a huge endorsement for Hindutva. That may embolden the Sangh Parivar in the way it crafts its ideological journey across the country in future.

THE FIVE YEARS AKHILESH SPENT IN THE OPPOSITION AFTER HIS PARTY WAS TROUNCED BY THE BJP IN 2017 SAW HIM MATURE INTO A WISER, CANNIER POLITICIAN—ENTIRELY HIS OWN BOSS

In Lucknow, a sense of the moment grips the BJP state headquarters. The innocuous-looking renovated PWD bungalow with tinted glass windows, which pales in comparison to the elegant colonial façade of Vidhan Bhavan next door, betrays no signs of its importance in architectural terms. But the way it came to life late last week, as Adityanath drove in with an entourage of white Toyota Fortuners, no one could doubt that it was the very cradle of possible futures. A crush of party workers hailed Adityanath with the party's new slogan: '*Soch Imaandar, Kaam Damdaar* (Honest in Thought, Powerful in Action)'. Inside a conference room packed to the brim with media, he along with other state and central leaders released the four-minute campaign theme song titled '*UP Phir Maange BJP Sarkar* (UP wants a BJP